

ARCHLOG



Documenting Design Thinking

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01



Problem Statement

Problem Statement

Across studio environments, students struggle to initiate and structure their design process, and once they're in motion, there's no consistent way to capture why they made the moves they made. Critiques rely on memory while decisions live in notebooks, Miro boards, and "shower thoughts." The result is a fragmented, hard-to-defend process that varies wildly from project to project and critic to critic.

We Asked:

How might we create an interactive, low-friction tool that enables architecture students to develop concepts with greater clarity within the studio environment?

02



The Research

Research Methods

A 5-section survey mapped habits, blockers, and tooling gaps. A focus group with 4 architecture students surfaced why the data looked the way it did. A/B usability studies with 6 students and our stakeholder, Prof. Aurora Bonomi, pressure-tested two design directions before we committed to a single path.

17+

Survey responses
from architecture
students in HCAD

4

Focus group
participants among
3rd-year students

6

A/B usability
sessions with
2nd-year students

Key Insights

Starting the project is the hardest part.

2 in every 3 students said their approach "depends on the project." Studio culture rewards adaptability, but leaves students without a methodology to lean on.

There is no shared design process.

7 out of 17 students stated that concept development is the most difficult phase. Nearly half also named iteration, indicating that motion stalls when the project begins.

Constraints don't restrict, they unlock.

Across interviews, structure was repeatedly framed as creative fuel. "One of the biggest things we're taught is to use constraints as an opportunity."

Key Insights

Decision-making is in students' heads.

There's no external scaffolding. Ideas surface in fragments (sketches, conversations, "shower thoughts", etc.) and rarely get captured in a way that survives to critique.

Critique is where the gap shows up.

Without a record of why a decision was made, students struggle to defend their work. The design narrative is reconstructed from memory, hours before the review.

03



Scope
Refinement

Seven concepts. One winner.

We tested seven feature concepts with focus group participants and asked them to rank what they'd actually use. The Design Decision Tracker finished first by a wide margin.

Three of four participants named it their top choice.



Participants prioritized tools that support decision-making and understanding design logic, confirming our research insight that **the gap isn't ideation, it's traceability.**

04



The Solution

The Solution

Decision Logging

Capture each design move with intent: what changed, why, and what it improves or trades off.

Project Overview

Upload visuals for each decision so the design iteration lives in the same place as the rationale.

Design Narratives

Generate a critique-ready story from your decision log. Walk into reviews prepared, not panicked.

Task Management

Track feedback and action items from your critiques or relevant design decisions.

Designer Profiles

Export your projects with ease to receive feedback and let your crits follow your thinking.

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[Click to play video prototype](#)

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[Link to Figma Prototype](#)

05



Limitations & Challenges

Limitations & Challenges

1

Brief Project Timeline

The 6-week timeframe limited opportunities for deeper iteration, extended testing, and long-term refinement of the prototype.

2

Limited Availability of Architecture Students

Recruiting and scheduling architecture students was challenging due to demanding studio schedules, critiques, and heavy academic workloads.

3

Small Participant Pool

All research methods were conducted with a relatively small group of students, which may not fully represent the broader architecture student experience.

4

Evolving & Broad Problem Space

Defining the project scope was itself a challenge, as research revealed a wide range of student needs and interpretations of what it means to “design better.”

06



What We
Recommend

Key Takeaways

Encourage Organized & Visible Design Processes

Push students to actively document and organize their design decisions, iterations, and process work throughout project, not just before final crits.

Support Personalized Organization Systems

Encourage students to build systems that work for them, whether through tools like Notion, sketch journals, or organized collections of references, inspirations, constraints, and recurring design preferences.

Encourage More Reflective Design Practices

Create opportunities for students to reflect on how and why their ideas evolved over time, reinforcing process and rationale as valuable parts of architectural learning.



Value their Process As Much As Their Results

Continue emphasizing **process visibility, iteration, and design rationale** as important parts of studio culture and learning.

Thank you



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